

Can the Dodo Come Back to Life? [C1]

Secondo Colossal Biosciences, tra circa un decennio migliaia di dodo potrebbero tornare ad abitare Mauritius. Si tratterebbe di una grande impresa scientifica o di un azzardo morale?

Since its [demise](#) in the 17th century, the dodo has long been synonymous with extinction. But thousands of dodos could soon again populate Mauritius, the species' former home, according to a de-extinction company that has announced a major [breakthrough](#) in its [quest](#) to resurrect the [flightless bird](#). Colossal Biosciences [said](#) on Wednesday it has succeeded in growing pigeon primordial [germ cells](#), precursor cells to sperm and [eggs](#), for the first time. This is a pivotal step in bringing back the dodo, which was a type of pigeon, for the first time in more than three hundred years, according to Colossal. The Texas-based company, which [has made splashy headlines](#) for its plans to reestablish [wooly mammoths](#) and [dire wolves](#), [said](#) it has also developed gene-edited chickens that will act as [surrogates](#) for the dodos. The chickens will be injected with primordial [germ cells](#) from Nicobar pigeons, the closest living [relatives](#) of dodos, which will in time, after gene edits to create the desired body and head shape, allow them to [breed](#) dodos. "[Rough ballpark, we think it's still five to seven years out](#), but it's not twenty years out," Ben Lamm, Colossal's chief executive, [said](#) about the timeline for the dodo's return. Colossal is working with wildlife groups to identify safe, rat-free sites in Mauritius where the species could once again [roam](#). "Our goal is to make enough dodos with enough genetic diversity engineered into them that we can put them back into the wild where they can truly [thrive](#)," he [said](#). "So we're not looking to make two dodos, we're looking to make thousands." Dodos once [plodded](#) the forests of Mauritius, located in the Indian Ocean, without predators until humans started killing them [in earnest](#), a process accelerated by European exploration and expansion. Habitat loss and introduced invasive species, such as macaques, pigs and rats that [raided](#) dodo [nests](#), [sealed the fate](#) of the largely defenseless, fruit-eating bird. The last reliable [sighting](#) of a dodo came from a Dutch sailor, who described it as a "kind of very big [goose](#)", in 1662. Colossal Biosciences CEO Ben Lamm with

a de-extinct dire wolf pup. The dodo has since become a [byword](#) for extinction but Colossal has [said](#) it is confident its methods, centered on its Crispr gene editing technology, can [turn the clock back](#) and return dodos to their former home. Beth Shapiro, Colossal's scientific chief who has a tattoo of a dodo on her arm, [said](#) the "super exciting" [breakthrough](#) came following a year of work to gene-edit birds, which are more complex to work on in this way than mammals. "This isn't a process where we're going to one day just throw thousands of dodos into Mauritius. Obviously it will be a slow and careful and deliberate process," [said](#) Shapiro. "If we can put back a large [ground-dwelling](#) fruit-eating bird, we don't know all of the consequences of putting them back on this landscape, but we anticipate that we will have some happy surprises." Current Affairs

The Problem With Antibiotics La loro scoperta ha contribuito a una società più sana e longeva, ma ne abbiamo abusato pericolosamente. È possibile usarli in modo sostenibile prima che sia troppo tardi? Daniel Francis Some experts, however, have [questioned](#) how to define these gene-edited species and what their roles would be in ecosystems degraded by human [encroachment](#) and the climate crisis. Leonardo Campagna, an evolutionary biologist at the Cornell Lab of Ornithology, [said](#) Colossal has made "some remarkable progress" but its dodo work faces numerous challenges. "It's hard to know what it took to make a dodo genetically, from its genomic architecture to how its genes interacted with the environment," Campagna [said](#). "Building an organism that looks like what we know the dodo did or behaved, which may not be the complete picture to begin with, including the unique shape of its face, its funny wings or its overall large size, is an arduous [endeavour](#). "I'd be curious to see a pigeon like that. But is this in fact the dodo? We need to acknowledge that there is a lot we don't know and maybe never will." About two million species are currently at risk of extinction, with animals and plants being threatened by the [razing](#) of habitat, rising temperatures, pollution, invasive species and hunting. The current extinction [rate](#) is hundreds of times faster than the historic norm, scientists estimate, due to the impact of humanity. While Colossal claims that its technology can [aid](#) endangered species rather than just resurrect lost relics, some experts claim its work diverts attention from threats to the natural world. Rich Grenyer, a biologist at the University of Oxford, [said](#) de-

extinction is a “dangerous” distraction and that gene-edited animals are “[at best](#) a sort of simulation, rather like those [unnerving](#) animated AI portraits of dead [relatives](#) we sometimes see people create.” “By labelling genetically-engineered modern species as extinct ones brought back from the dead, if it [takes off](#), it’s a huge [moral hazard](#); a massive [enabler](#) for the activities that causes species to go extinct in the first place — habitat destruction, mass killing and anthropogenic climate change,” he [said](#).

“There’s also of course the [quest](#)ion of where you’re going to put your newly-engineered hybrids, if they’re not just going to be curiosities in a zoo, because it’s generally the lack of habitat that caused the problem in the first place.” Colossal’s ongoing ascent, though, was [underlined](#) on Wednesday when it announced it extended its [funding round](#) by £120 million, with the company now valued at £10.2 billion. Celebrity investors, such as Tom Brady, Paris Hilton and Tiger Woods, have [flocked to](#) the business. Peter Jackson, the Lord of the Rings director and another investor, appeared in a recent Colossal video to promote its effort to de-extinct the moa, an enormous [flightless bird](#) once found in Jackson’s native New Zealand. Professor Ian Wilmut with Dolly the sheep on display in the National Museums of Scotland. Lamm [said](#) Colossal’s activities should act in tandem with other conservation work, and that its recent announcements would help inspire people about science. “The dire wolf is a monumental [feat](#) of genome engineering that has never been achieved before by any academic lab or by any other company ever, it is literally a [testament to](#) science, it’s a Dolly-esque moment, full stop,” he [said](#), in reference to the famously cloned sheep. “These are dodos, and I’m sure there will be some people who say, ‘Oh, well, we don’t like them. We’re not going to call them dodos,’” Lamm [said](#) of the latest Colossal project. “Then don’t. We just don’t care, and the more you don’t call them a dodo, the more [controversy you drive](#), the more my numbers go up. So that’s great. So, whatever you want to call them, as long as you’re calling them something.” Published in The Guardian on 17 September 2025. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **thrive** = prosperare
- **wooly mammoths** = mammut lanosi
- **plodded** = camminare pesantemente
- **nests** = nidi
- **byword** = sinonimo
- **turn the clock back** = tornare indietro nel tempo
- **encroachment** = invasione
- **endeavour** = impresa
- **razing** = radere al suolo, distruzione
- **flightless bird** = uccello che non vola
- **eggs** = ovuli
- **Rough ballpark** = stima approssimativa
- **ground-dwelling** = terricolo
- **aid** = aiutare
- **at best** = nel migliore dei casi
- **testament to** = dimostrazione di
- **quest** = ricerca
- **goose** = oca
- **feat** = impresa, prodezza
- **breakthrough** = svolta decisiva
- **sighting** = avvistamento
- **takes off** = decollare
- **funding round** = round di investimenti
- **controversy you drive** = generare controversie
- **relatives** = parenti
- **moral hazard** = azzardo morale
- **flocked to** = accorrere
- **germ cells** = cellule germinali
- **in earnest** = seriamente, con impegno
- **raided** = saccheggiare
- **sealed the fate** = segnare il destino
- **unnerving** = inquietanti, destabilizzanti
- **has made splashy headlines** = fare titoloni da prima pagina

- **surrogates** = gestanti surrogate
- **it's still five to seven years out** = mancare (tempo)
- **roam** = vagare
- **rate** = tasso, indice
- **enabler** = complice, abilitatore
- **underlined** = sottolineare, mettere in evidenza
- **demise** = scomparsa, estinzione
- **dire wolves** = lupi terribili (grandi lupi preistorici)
- **breed** = riprodurre